

Pictures of the Great Gate

This building was designed to mark a transition between two worlds: the outer and the inner, the profane and the sacred, of the living and of the dead. This division and transition are important elements of Islamic spatial and architectural thinking. The outer world is dedicated to commerce and is the space of men, and in this case it consists of the bazaar, while the inner world is one of beauty, gardens and women, which for the Taj consists of the Mausoleum and gardens.

While many Western observers might immediately associate this outside-inside divide with the practice of purdah - the veiling of women from immodest gaze - it is broader than simply that practice. For instance, in the earlier 15th century Topkapı Palace in Istanbul, the home of the Ottoman Sultan, foreign dignitaries passed through various outer courts, moving inwards through gates into deeper levels of privacy, beauty and sanctity until their meeting with the sultan, who was hidden behind a screen. On a much more common level, neighborhoods throughout Islamic cities were often semi-